Staff answers & diagnostic guide — Make the identity piece: pattern and portrait

Pathway: TRACK · Week 4 Part 1 · Big question: How can we combine a bold repeating background pattern with a high-contrast central identity subject?

Starter answer & explanation

Question: Why does combining oil pastel with a translucent ink wash work so well for a patterned background?

Correct: You can draw repeating pastel patterns quickly and sweep a contrasting wash right across to fill the gaps — Yes! Oil pastel resists the watery wash, giving you a rich two-colour background fast.

Guided team check (We do) answers

Q1: What should you do if wet background wash accidentally beads near the edge of your central subject? -> Blot it gently with a clean tissue corner before coloring the inside of the subject (Correct. Blotting straight away keeps the central subject crisp and dry.)

Q2: How do you create strong figure-ground contrast if your background is dark indigo and amber? -> Keep the central subject predominantly bright and warm with crisp dark internal details (Yes. Bright tones against a deep background make the focal point unmistakable.)

Q3: Why do we apply the thick black contour line around the subject at the end rather than before the wet wash? -> Applying the final line once the wash is touch-dry keeps the black edge razor-sharp with zero bleeding (Spot on. Dry ink over dry wash locks every edge cleanly.)

Exit check answer

Question: What does 'figure-ground separation' mean in a composition?

Correct: Making sure the main subject stands out clearly from the patterned background behind it — Correct. Contrast in tone, colour, or line weight separates the figure from the ground.